

The Gospel according to Luke

Introduction

The Gospel according to Luke was written by a companion of Paul, believed to be Luke the Evangelist, around 80-90 AD (approximately 60 years after the death of Christ). The same author also wrote the Book of Acts, making them a logical two volume set. As with the other synoptic gospels, much material is shared and scholars have proposed that all three (Matthew, Mark, and Luke) share a unique source, *Q*. This has not been verified though.

Luke was writing to a primarily Gentile audience, unlike Matthew, and could therefore exclude much of the highlighting of Old Testament scripture and its links to Jesus being the Messiah, in favor of a more direct exposition of Christian theology (for example, the Sermon on the Plain doesn't have any of the references to the Law of Moses that the Sermon on the Mount contains).

Forasmuch as many have taken in hand to set forth in order a declaration of those things which are most surely believed among us, ²Even as they delivered them unto us, which from the beginning were eyewitnesses, and ministers of the word; ³It seemed good to me also, having had perfect understanding of all things from the very first, to write unto thee in order, most excellent Theophilus, ⁴That thou mightest know the certainty of those things, wherein thou hast been instructed.

John the Baptist Announced

⁵There was in the days of Herod, the king of Judaea, a certain priest named Zacharias, of the course of Abia: and his wife was of the daughters of Aaron, and her name was Elisabeth. ⁶And they were both righteous before God, **walking** in all the commandments and ordinances of the Lord blameless. ⁷And they had no child, because that Elisabeth was barren, and they both were now well stricken in years. ⁸And it came to pass, that while he executed the priest's office before God in the order of his course, ⁹According to the custom of the priest's office, his lot was to burn incense when he went into the temple of the Lord. ¹⁰And the whole multitude of the people were praying without at the time of incense. ¹¹And there appeared unto him an angel of **the Lord** standing on the **right side** of the altar of incense. ¹²And when Zacharias saw him, he was troubled, and fear fell upon him. ¹³But the angel said unto him, **Fear not**, Zacharias: for thy prayer is heard; and thy wife Elisabeth shall bear thee a son, and thou shalt call his name John. ¹⁴And thou shalt have **joy and gladness**; and many shall rejoice at his birth. ¹⁵For he shall be great in the sight of the Lord, and shall drink neither wine nor strong drink; and he shall be filled with the **Holy Ghost**, even from his mother's womb. ¹⁶And many of the children of Israel shall he turn to the Lord their God. ¹⁷And he shall go before him in the spirit and power of Elias, to turn **the hearts of the fathers**

1:6 Walking. AE 97 Walking in the Word refers to **living**. **Ways** refers to truths by which one 'walks' or lives.

1:11 The Lord. AC 2921:5 Throughout the New Testament, God is referred to as **the Lord** instead of Yahweh/Jehovah because a) if he had taken this name on people would not have believed him and b) he was not Yahweh/Jehovah until the last temptation (the crucifixion) because at that point he unified his Divine Essence with his Human Essence.

Right side. AE 298:13 The **right side** refers to, in the context of men and angels in the Word, the wisdom and intelligence that they have from Divine good through Divine truth proceeding from the Lord. The angel therefore appeared to Zacharias in the wisdom and intelligence that they had from the Lord.

1:13 Fear not. AE 80, AE 677:8 In the Word, 'the fearful' are those who are in no faith, as Zacharias is here. **Fear** signifies in the Word various disturbances of mind arising from the influx of Divine Good and Truth. In the world, all those who come suddenly from their own life into a life which is in some degree spiritual, are at first afraid, but are renewed by the Lord. This renewal, or resuscitation, is effected by the Divine presence, accommodated to the person's own reception of good by means of truth, and is signified by **Fear not**. It then leads to a new life of increased humility and adoration. i.e. **Zacharias (those without faith) is renewed by the Lord by means of whatever good and truth he possessed.**

1:14 Joy and gladness. AE 660:4, AR 507 **Joy and Gladness** in the Word signify the delights of the will and the understanding. **Joy** signifies pleasure from good and **Gladness** signifies pleasure from truth. These two phrases go together throughout the Word and indicate the heavenly marriage of good and truth. **Zacharias (the fearful; without faith) will be or has been renewed by the Lord, and will go on to experience these delights.**

1:15 Holy Ghost. AE 710:31 That John the Baptist was to be filled with the **Holy Ghost** signifies that he was to represent the Lord in relation to the Word, as Elijah did. In the Word, which is Divine truth, there is everywhere the marriage of Divine good and Divine truth, and Divine good united with Divine truth is the Divine proceeding from the Lord, which is called the Holy Spirit.

1:17 The spirit and power of Elijah. AC 6752 As in other places in the Word, Elijah represents the Lord in relation to the Word. Elijah represents the Word as to the Prophetic books, Moses represents the Word as to the Historical books/the Law. For John the Baptist to come 'in the spirit and power of Elijah' shows that he was to take up this mantle as well. 'Spirit' corresponds to Divine Truth, while 'Power' corresponds to Divine Good.

The hearts of the fathers to the children. AC 3703:9 **The hearts of the fathers and children** signify the the goods and truths of the church, which the Lord was about to restore.

to the children, and the disobedient to the wisdom of the just; to make ready a people prepared for the Lord. ¹⁸ And Zacharias said unto the angel, Whereby shall I know this? for I am an old man, and my wife well stricken in years. ¹⁹ And the angel answering said unto him, I am Gabriel, **that stand in the presence of God**; and am sent to speak unto thee, and to shew thee these glad tidings. ²⁰ And, behold, thou shalt be dumb, and not able to speak, until the day that these things shall be performed, because thou believest not my words, which shall be fulfilled in their season. ²¹ And the people waited for Zacharias, and marvelled that he tarried so long in the temple. ²² And when he came out, he could not speak unto them: and they perceived that he had seen a vision in the temple: for he beckoned unto them, and remained speechless. ²³ And it came to pass, that, as soon as the days of his ministration were accomplished, he departed to his own house. ²⁴ And after those days his wife Elisabeth conceived, and hid herself five months, saying, ²⁵ Thus hath the Lord dealt with me in the days wherein **he looked on me, to take away my reproach among men**.

The Annunciation

²⁶ And in the sixth month the angel Gabriel was sent from God unto a city of Galilee, named Nazareth, ²⁷ To a virgin espoused to a man whose name was Joseph, of the house of David; and the virgin's name was Mary. ²⁸ And the angel came in unto her, and said, Hail, thou that art highly favoured, the Lord is with thee: blessed art thou among women. ²⁹ And when she saw him, she was troubled at his saying, and cast in her mind what manner of salutation this should be. ³⁰ And the angel said unto her, Fear not, Mary: for thou hast found favour with God. ³¹ And, behold, thou shalt conceive in thy womb, and bring forth a son, and shalt call his name JESUS. ³² He shall be great, and shall be called the **Son of the Highest**: and the Lord God shall give unto him the throne of his father David: ³³ And he shall **reign over the house of Jacob** for ever; and **of his kingdom there shall be no end**. ³⁴ Then said Mary unto the angel, How shall this be, seeing I know not a man? ³⁵ And the angel answered and said unto her, **The Holy Ghost shall come upon thee, and the power of the Highest shall overshadow thee**: therefore also that holy thing which shall be born of thee shall be called the **Son of God**. ³⁶ And, behold, thy cousin Elisabeth, she hath also conceived a son in her old age: and this is the sixth month with her, who was called barren. ³⁷ For with God nothing shall be impossible. ³⁸ And Mary said, Behold the handmaid of the Lord; be it unto me according to thy word. And the angel departed from her.

Mary visits Elizabeth

³⁹ And Mary arose in those days, and went into the hill country with haste, into a city of Juda; ⁴⁰ And entered into the house of Zacharias, and saluted Elisabeth. ⁴¹ And it came to pass, that, when Elisabeth heard the salutation of Mary, **the babe leaped in her womb**; and Elisabeth was **filled with the Holy Ghost**:

1:19 That stand in the presence of God. AE 414, AR 366 To stand in the presence of God signifies one's ability to receive Divine Truth and live by it. The evil are not able to stand before God in heaven because they find the influx of Divine Good and Truth unbearable, but the good are able to withstand that influx without problem.

1:25 He looked on me, to take away my reproach among men. AE 721:16 Since a "mother" signifies the church, and "sons and daughters" its truths and goods, and in the ancient churches, and afterwards in the Jewish church, all things were representative or significative, it was a reproach and disgrace for women to be barren, as in Gen. 30 where Rachel's reproach is taken away when she bears Joseph.

1:32 Son of the Highest. Lord 29:2 The fact that the Lord is called the **Son of the Highest** is evidence of the fact that he was the Divine as to his spirit, while while his Human was from Mary. Where one part is Divine, the other must be as well, showing that he united his Divine to his Human. This also shows that the Father was in the Son, and vice versa, i.e. there is no separation of entities in God. The Divine Soul and Human physical cannot be separated any more than any mortal man's soul and body.

1:33 Reign over the house of Jacob. AC 3305:3 By **Jacob** in the word is signified the doctrine of natural truth. Here **the house of Jacob** was not used to mean the Jewish nation or people, because the Lord's kingdom included not merely that people, but people throughout the world who have faith in Him, and from faith have charity.

Of his kingdom there shall be no end. AE 1104:5 While churches

come and go, as has happened four times on Earth already, when the Word refers to things of the Lord or Heaven in terms of ages or epochs, it is referring to what is timeless and eternal in those things, namely Good and Truth. The Lord's kingdom (his Good and Truth) actually are without end; it is only humans and their receptivity that limit this.

1:35 The Holy Ghost shall come upon thee, and the power of the Highest shall overshadow thee. Ath 45-46, Can 17 The Lord's spirit was from the Father, not Mary or Joseph i.e. he was fully God. **The Holy Ghost** signifies Divine Truth, while the **power of the Highest** signifies Divine Good. In the Lord, these two were initially separate, as in man, but were united in time, just as they are united in man through regeneration.

Son of God. AE 1069:2, TCR 342 God's Essence is his Divine Love, from which proceeds his Divine Good and Truth (his Existence, or manifestation). Since the Lord is the Word in multiple ways and because he proceeds from the Divine Essence, he is called the **Son of God**. Since there is no way to have faith in Christ without acknowledging his Divinity, this is a core principle of Christianity. Without it, we would need to have faith in a man, which is a damaging doctrine, seen paralleled by the crown of thorns, and the taunting that Christ received on the cross to save himself.

1:41 The babe leaped in her womb. AE 710:31 John leaping in the womb at the greeting from Mary represents the joy arising from the love of the conjunction of good and truth, thus the joy of heavenly conjugal love, which is in every particular of the Word.

⁴² And she spake out with a loud voice, and said, Blessed art thou among women, and blessed is the fruit of thy womb. ⁴³ And whence is this to me, that the mother of my Lord should come to me? ⁴⁴ For, lo, as soon as the voice of thy salutation sounded in mine ears, the babe leaped in my womb for joy. ⁴⁵ And blessed is she that believed: for there shall be a performance of those things which were told her from the Lord. ⁴⁶ And Mary said,

My soul doth magnify the Lord,

⁴⁷ And my **spirit** hath rejoiced in God my Saviour.

⁴⁸ For he hath regarded the low estate of his handmaiden:
for, behold, from henceforth all generations shall call me blessed.

⁴⁹ For he that is mighty hath done to me great things;
and holy is his name.

⁵⁰ And his mercy is on **them that fear him** from generation to generation.

⁵¹ He hath shewed strength with his arm;
he hath scattered the proud in the imagination of their hearts.

⁵² He hath put down the mighty from their seats,
and exalted them of low degree.

⁵³ He hath filled the hungry with good things;
and the rich he hath sent empty away.

⁵⁴ He hath holpen his servant Israel, in remembrance of his mercy; ⁵⁵ As he spake to our fathers, to Abraham, and to his seed for ever. ⁵⁶ And Mary abode with her about three months, and returned to her own house. ⁵⁷ Now Elisabeth's full time came that she should be delivered; and she brought forth a son. ⁵⁸ And her neighbours and her cousins heard how the Lord had shewed great mercy upon her; and they rejoiced with her. ⁵⁹ And it came to pass, that on the eighth day they came to circumcise the child; and they called him Zacharias, after the name of his father. ⁶⁰ And his mother answered and said, Not so; but he shall be called John. ⁶¹ And they said unto her, There is none of thy kindred that is called by this name. ⁶² And they made signs to his father, how he would have him called. ⁶³ And he asked for a writing table, and wrote, saying, His name is John. And they marvelled all. ⁶⁴ And his mouth was opened immediately, and his tongue loosed, and he spake, and praised God. ⁶⁵ And fear came on all that dwelt round about them: and all these sayings were noised abroad throughout all the hill country of Judaea. ⁶⁶ And all they that heard them laid them up in their hearts, saying, What manner of child shall this be! And the hand of the Lord was with him. ⁶⁷ And his father Zacharias was filled with the Holy Ghost, and prophesied, saying, ⁶⁸ Blessed be the Lord God of Israel; for he hath visited and redeemed his people, ⁶⁹ And hath raised up an horn of salvation for us in the house of his servant David; ⁷⁰ As he spake by the mouth of his holy prophets, which have been since the world began: ⁷¹ That we should be saved from our enemies, and from the hand of all that hate us; ⁷² To perform the mercy promised to our fathers, and to remember his holy covenant; ⁷³ The oath which he swore to our father Abraham, ⁷⁴ That he would grant unto us, that we being delivered out of the hand of our enemies might serve him without fear, ⁷⁵ In holiness and righteousness before him, all the days of our life. ⁷⁶ And thou, child, shalt be called the prophet of the Highest: for thou shalt go before the face of the Lord to prepare his ways; ⁷⁷ To give knowledge of salvation unto his people by the remission of their sins, ⁷⁸ Through the tender mercy of our God; whereby the dayspring from on high hath visited us, ⁷⁹ To give light to them that sit in darkness and in the shadow of death, to guide our feet into the way of peace. ⁸⁰ And the child grew, and waxed strong in spirit, and was in the deserts till the day of his shewing unto Israel.

Filled with the Holy Ghost. *Lord 51:5, TCR 158* The **Holy Ghost** is the Divine proceeding, or the Divine Life emanating from the Word. This can also be expressed as the unified Divine Love and Wisdom proceeding from the Lord, expressed in someone leading a regenerate life. It is worth noting that the **Holy Ghost** isn't mentioned in the Old Testament, but the Spirit of Holiness is mentioned three times. This is because the **Holy Ghost** emanates from the Lord, and couldn't not proceed from Him until He had been born in this world.

1:46 My soul. *AE 750:5* The **soul** has several meanings within the Word: in general, it means man and everything pertaining to him, more specifically it means a man's spiritual life, and more specific still

it means the life of a man's understanding.

1:47 Spirit. *Lord 49* The **spirit** refers to the life of a regenerate person, or the spiritual life i.e. the life the Lord intends for us.

1:50 Them that fear him. *AE 696:21, AR 527:2* The **fear** of the Lord signifies having a sense of holiness and reverence and accordingly worshiping with holiness and reverence. It does not signify the same negative fearfulness we interpret in modern language, it signifies the opposite. "To fear" signifies to love because everyone who loves also fears to do evil to him whom he loves. Genuine love is not given without that fear.